

Align with Project PHEONIX

1 Introduction

This document outlines how the PHOENIX Privacy Rules align with the project's objectives, architecture, and operational context. PHOENIX operates in a high-risk environment where cybercriminals exploit natural disasters through scams, misinformation, and targeted attacks on emergency services. Evidence from Scamwatch shows that “scammers also follow disasters in order to take advantage of the generosity” of donors, while the FRV ransomware attack in 2022 “continues to severely impact” emergency operations months after the incident.

Given these conditions, privacy is not merely a compliance requirement but a foundational component of PHOENIX's mission to protect communities and maintain trust during crises.

2 Purpose of project Alignment

The purpose of this document is to:

- Demonstrate how PHOENIX's privacy rules directly support project objectives
- Ensure privacy principles are embedded across all work packages (ADCRS, TEAVS)
- Provide a governance framework that integrates legal, ethical, and operational privacy requirements
- Show how privacy safeguards reduce risks identified in the project's evidence base.

3 Alignment With PHOENIX Objectives

PHOENIX has four core objectives. The privacy rules align with each as follows:

3.1 Objective 1 - Reduce Fraud and Misinformation

Alignment:

Privacy rules ensure that scam-related data, misinformation indicators, and threat intelligence are collected and processed ethically and securely. By enforcing minimal data collection and secure storage, PHOENIX prevents misuse of sensitive information that could otherwise be exploited by malicious actors.

Evidence Link:

Over 500 bushfire-related scams circulated during Black Summer, demonstrating the need for strict privacy controls to prevent further exploitation of victims.

3.2 Objective 2 - Protect Critical Services

Alignment:

Privacy rules mandate encryption, access control, and secure handling of emergency-service communication metadata. These safeguards reduce the risk of operational disruption, data leakage, or unauthorised access to sensitive systems.

Evidence Link:

The FRV ransomware attack crippled dispatch systems, highlighting the need for privacy-aligned security controls to protect emergency-service data.

3.3 Objective 3 - Boost Community Trust in Official Alerts

Alignment:

Privacy rules ensure that TEAVS cryptographic signatures do not expose personal information and that alert verification processes are transparent, secure, and privacy-preserving. This strengthens public trust in authenticated communications.

Evidence Link:

During the Black Summer, misinformation spread rapidly, undermining trust in official sources. Privacy-aligned alert verification helps counter this.

3.4 Objective 4 - Provide a Scalable Cyber Resilience Blueprint

Alignment:

Privacy rules form a core component of the Cyber Resilience Blueprint, ensuring that councils adopting PHOENIX have clear, legally compliant privacy guidance. This

supports long-term scalability and integration into Municipal Emergency Management Plans (MEMPs).

4 Alignment With PHOENIX Architecture

PHOENIX consists of two major technical components: ADCRS and TEAVS. Privacy rules align with each as follows:

4.1 ADCRS (AI-Driven Cyber Risk Simulator)

Privacy Alignment Requirements:

- Minimal collection of personal data from Scamwatch, ATO, and LGA feeds
- Anonymisation of threat intelligence inputs
- Secure storage of hazard-to-threat correlation outputs
- Human oversight of AI-generated risk assessments
- Documentation of data sources and retention periods

Rationale:

ADCRS processes sensitive cyber-threat indicators; privacy safeguards prevent misuse or re-identification.

4.2 TEAVS (Trusted Emergency Alert Verification System)

Privacy Alignment Requirements:

- Cryptographic signatures must not contain personal identifiers
- Verification logs must be anonymised
- Alert metadata must be stored securely
- Public verification must not expose internal system details
- Key management must follow strict privacy and security protocols

Rationale:

TEAVS interacts directly with the public; privacy alignment is essential to maintain trust and prevent spoofing.

5 Alignment With Legal and Ethical Frameworks

PHOENIX privacy rules align with:

- Privacy Act 1988
- Australian Privacy Principles (APPs)
- Victorian Protective Data Security Standards (VPDSS)
- Ethical principles of non-maleficence, autonomy, and justice
- Emergency management obligations under Victorian legislation

This alignment ensures PHOENIX meets both legal compliance and ethical expectations for protecting vulnerable communities.

6 Alignment With Identified Risks

The privacy rules directly mitigate risks identified in the project's evidence base:

Risk Identified	Evidence Source	Privacy Alignment
Scam exploitation during disasters	Scamwatch, ABC	Minimal data collection, secure storage, access control
Misinformation amplification	ABC investigation	Privacy-preserving alert verification (TEAVS)
Ransomware attacks on emergency services	FRV 2022 incident	Encryption, RBAC, secure key management
Misuse of sensitive community data	Scamwatch reports	Data minimisation, anonymisation, retention limits

7 Conclusion

This document ensures that privacy is embedded across all aspects of PHOENIX, aligning directly with the project's objectives, architecture, and ethical responsibilities. By integrating privacy-by-design principles into ADCRS, TEAVS, and the Cyber Resilience Blueprint, PHOENIX strengthens community trust, protects vulnerable populations, and ensures compliance with Australian privacy legislation.